

employees of the bankrupt firm Lehman Brothers^{*}), which I found extremely flattering, and, worse than any threat of violence, hourly requests for interviews by Turkish and Brazilian journalists. I had to spend a lot of time writing personalized and courteous notes declining invitations to dinner with suit-wearing current hotshots, suit-wearing archeo-hotshots, suit-wearing proto-hotshots, and the nasty brand of suit-wearing namedroppers. But it also brought some benefits. I was contacted by like-minded persons, people I would have never dreamed of meeting in the past, or those I did not think existed before, in disciplines completely outside my normal circles, who helped me further my quest with the most unexpected of ideas. I was often reached by people I admired and whose work I knew well, and who became natural collaborators and critics; I will always remember the thrill of getting an unexpected e-mail from Spyros Makridakis of the M-Competition described in [Chapter 10](#), the great debunker of misforecasting, or another one from Jon Elster, the scholar of rare erudition and insights who integrated the wisdom of the ancients into modern social science thinking. I've met novelists and philosophical thinkers whose works I had read and admired, like Louis de Bernières, Will Self, John Gray (the philosopher, not the pop psychologist), or Lord Martin Rees; in all four cases I had the peculiar need to pinch myself upon hearing them talking to me about *my own* book.

Then, through a chain of friends of friends, cappuccinos, dessert wines, and security lines at airports, I got to partake of and understand the potency of oral knowledge, as discussions are vastly more powerful than just correspondence. People say things in person they would never put in print. I met Nouriel Roubini (to my knowledge the only professional economist who *really* predicted the crisis of 2008, and perhaps the only independent thinker in that business). I also found a variety of people I did not know existed, *good* economists (i.e., with scientific standards), like Michael Spence and Barkley Rosser. Also Peter Bevelin and Yechezkel Zilber kept feeding me the papers I was looking for without knowing it, the first in biology, the second in cognitive science—thus they nudged my thinking in the appropriate direction.

So I have been dialoguing with many people. My problem is that I found only two persons who can have a conversation during a long walk (and walk slowly): Spyros Makridakis and Yechezkel Zilber. Most people, alas, walk too fast, mistaking walking for exercise, not understanding that walking is to be done slowly, at such a pace that one forgets one is walking—so I need to keep going to Athens (where Spyros